

Caisson GTM & Customer Acquisition

Decision-grade go-to-market plan for a paid source-code developer product

Primary motion

content-led compliance wedge

Model

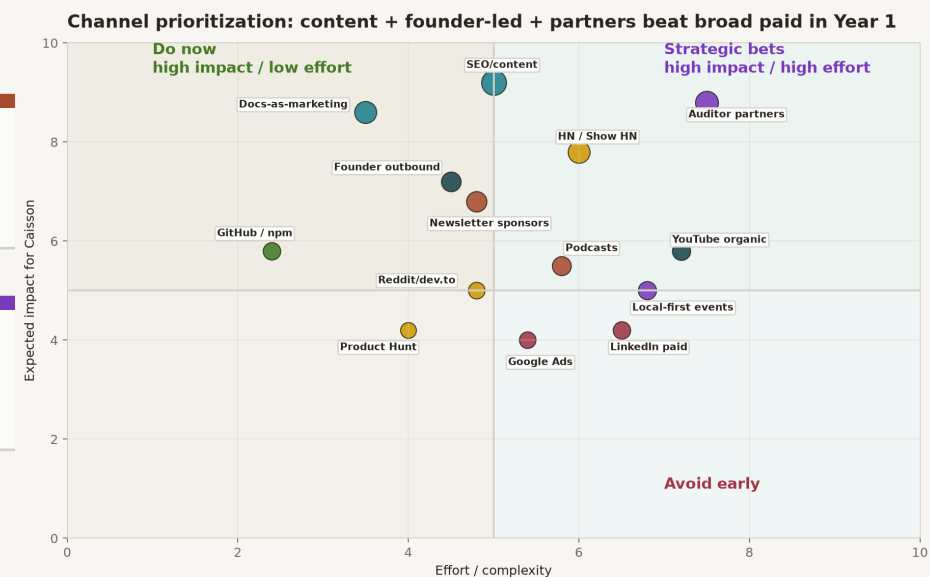
one-time purchase + update subscription

Beachhead

Series A-B regulated AI teams

Prepared June 28, 2026

Prepared June 28, 2026



Executive Summary

The recommended GTM in one page.

Motion

Primary: content-led inbound around EU AI Act, SOC2-as-code, and compliance engineering. Secondary: community-seeded GitHub/HN discovery.

Beachhead

Series A-B fintech/healthtech AI teams with TypeScript/Next.js, enterprise compliance pressure, and Cursor/Claude Code usage.

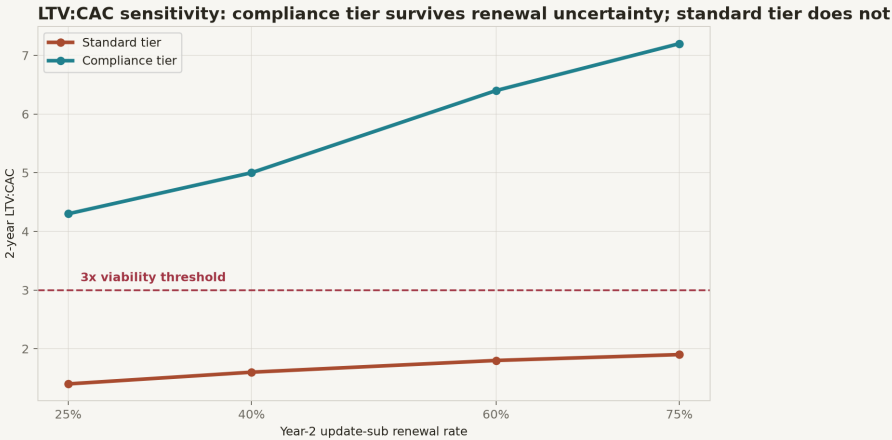
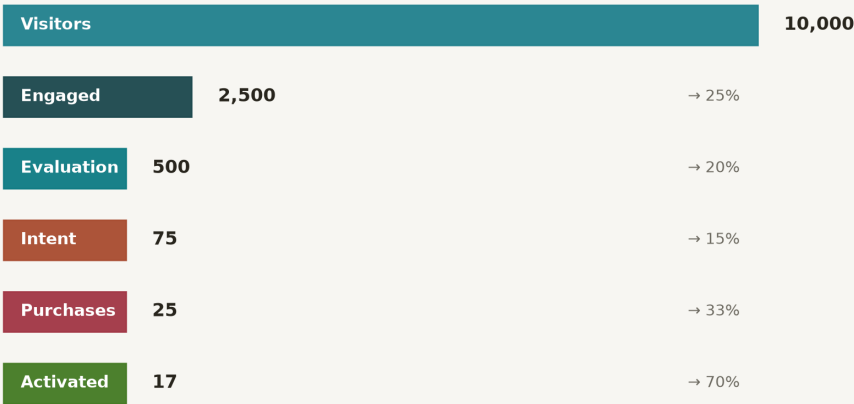
Economics

Compliance tier carries the model: ~2.2-2.4 month payback and ~6x 2-year LTV:CAC at 60% update renewal.

Do not copy SaaS PLG

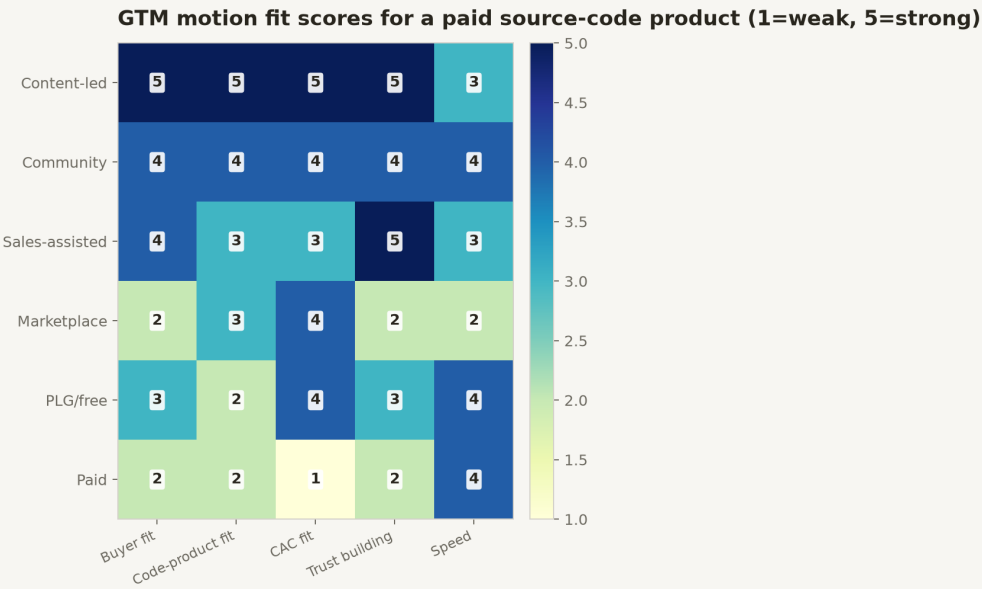
No hosted free tier, no vendor telemetry, no seat expansion. Use free code sample, docs, and founder-assisted close instead.

Modeled monthly acquisition funnel at steady state (months 6-12)



GTM Motion Selection

Content-led compliance inbound is the primary motion; community and founder-led sales support it.



Motion	Role	Why
Content/SEO	Primary	High intent, low CPL, trust building
Community	Secondary	Proof and feedback; unreliable direct conversion
Founder-led sales	Compliance only	Needed for high-ticket trust and objection discovery
PLG/free	Evaluation aid	Free code sample replaces hosted trial
Paid	Narrow tests	CPC/CPL too high before conversion proof

Beachhead, Triggers, and Messaging

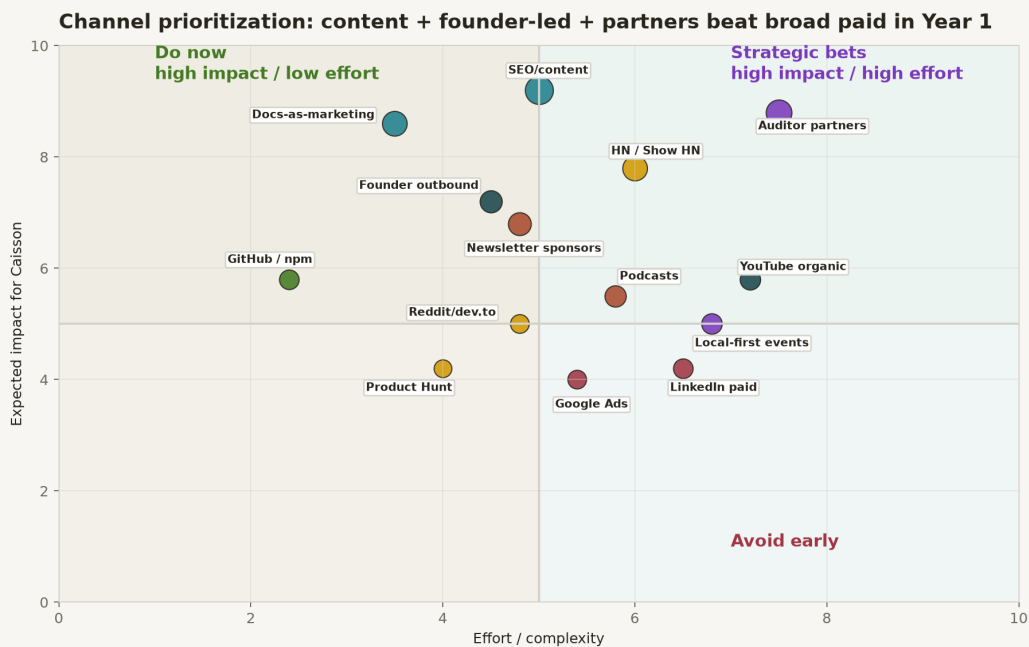
Win one narrow segment before expanding.

Persona / segment	Trigger	Channel	Lead message
Series A-B fintech AI team	SOC2 + enterprise buyer + EU exposure	SEO + founder outbound	Compliance controls live in the code path
Healthtech platform lead	HIPAA + AI feature launch	SEO + vCISO refs	Audit trails, encryption, evidence packs in repo
AI-native SaaS CTO	LLM cost/governance issue	HN/X + content	Production-rigor AI kit without extra vendors
Compliance consultant	Repeat client implementation	Partner referral	Reusable code layer for client controls
Platform/agentic lead	Cursor/Claude rollout	GitHub + community	Governed agent-readable repo standard

Acquisition narrative: Compliance is not just a dashboard. For regulated AI SaaS, the controls that matter most are application architecture: WORM audit logs, tamper-evident records, tenant encryption, prompt/eval evidence, and signed evidence packs.

Channel Strategy and Ranking

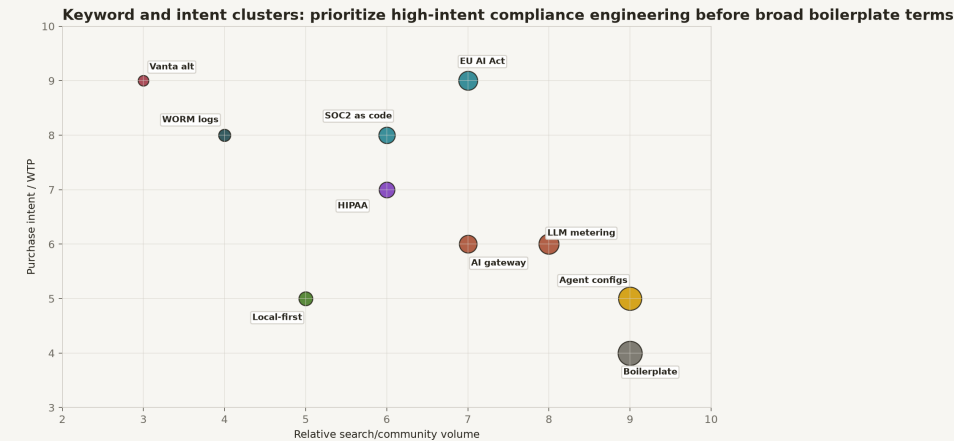
Effort vs. impact and first plays for every plausible channel.



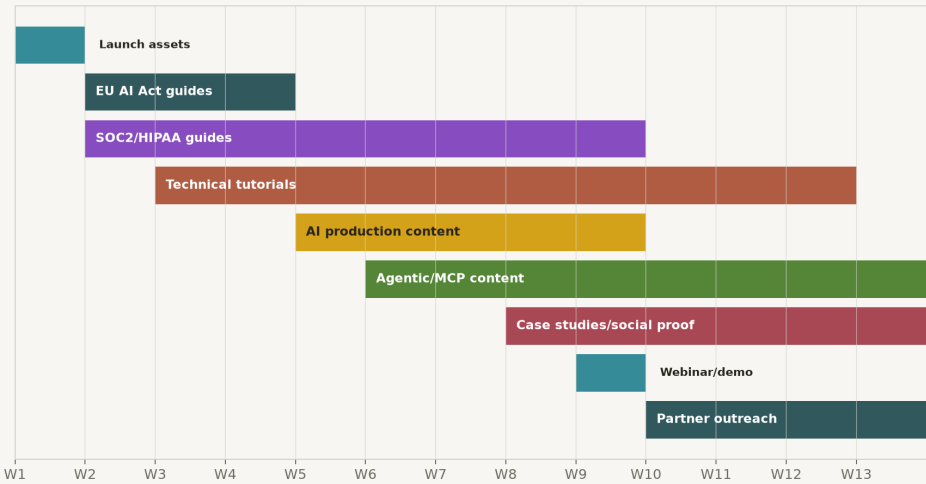
Channel	Modeled economics	First play
SEO/docs	\$150-\$600 CAC	EU AI Act engineering checklist + WORM tutorial
Founder outbound	\$800-\$1,200 CAC incl. time	50 named fintech/healthtech CTOs
Partners	20% referral commission	5 compliance consultants with demo kit
Newsletter	\$90-\$150 CPM	TLDR/security newsletter vanity URL test
Paid search	\$6-\$10 CPC	Exact-match retargeting only after proof
LinkedIn	\$188-\$791 CPL	Sponsored messages only to named ICP

Content and SEO Engine

Docs-as-marketing, keyword clusters, and 90-day content sequence.



90-day content engine: weekly publishing cadence

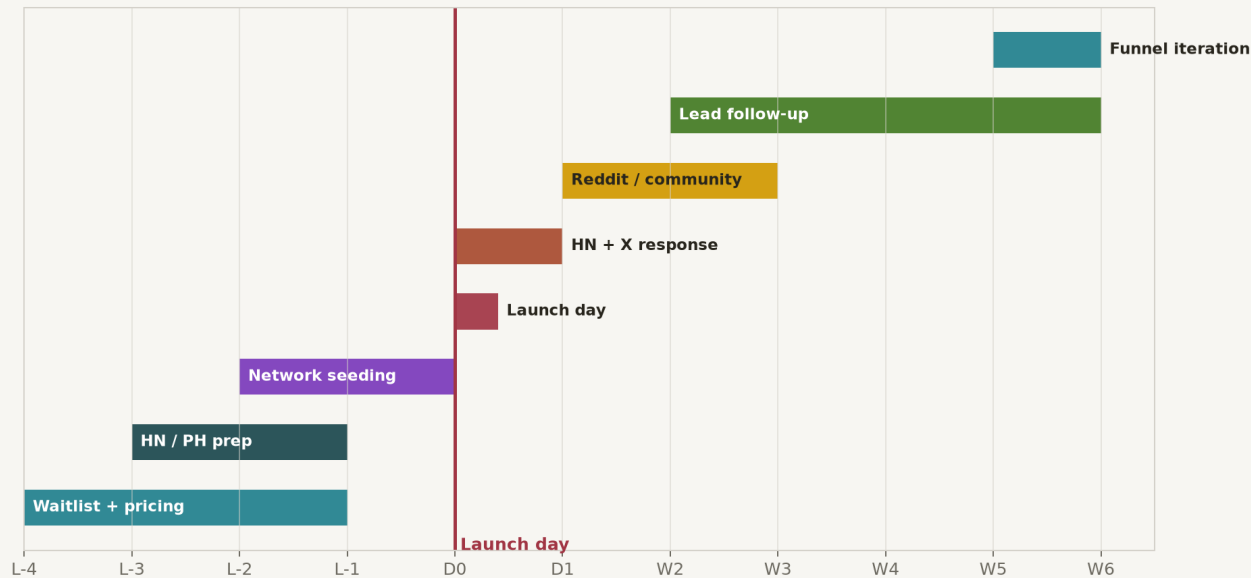


Pillar	Examples
EU AI Act engineering	Articles 9-15 checklist; Annex IV starter
SOC2/HIPAA code controls	SOC2 Type II in a monorepo; HIPAA for engineers
Compliance primitives	WORM logs; hash-chain audit trails; encryption
AI production	LLM cost metering; eval CI gates; prompt registry
Comparison pages	Vanta vs Caisson; Makerkit vs Caisson

Launch Strategy

Pre-launch seeding matters more than Product Hunt theater.

Launch sequence: pre-seeding matters more than launch-day theater



Phase	Assets	Target
L-4 to L-1	Waitlist, HN/PH drafts, GitHub README, payment/licensing, 10-15 seeded ICP leads	200+ emails
Day 0-1	Founder blog, Show HN, PH, X thread, waitlist email, comment response	50+ HN upvotes, 20 comments
Weeks 2-6	Follow-up, WORM tutorial, funnel analysis, pricing/copy iteration	First compliance close

Funnel and Conversion Benchmarks

A purchased code product converts through evaluation trust, not hosted trial telemetry.

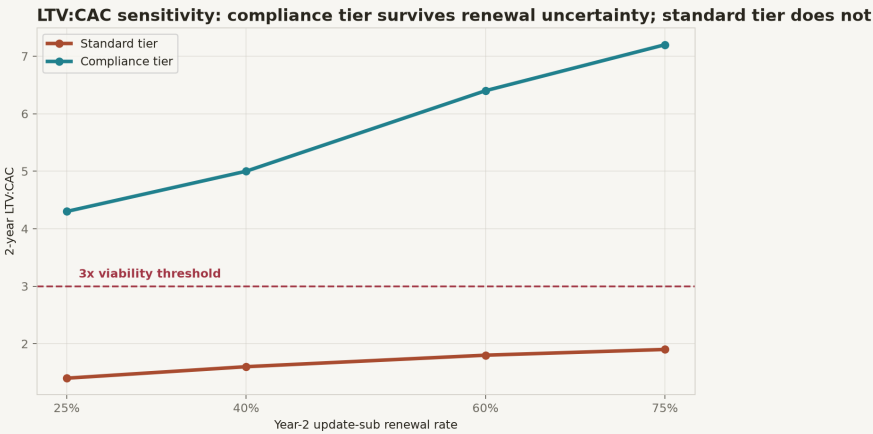
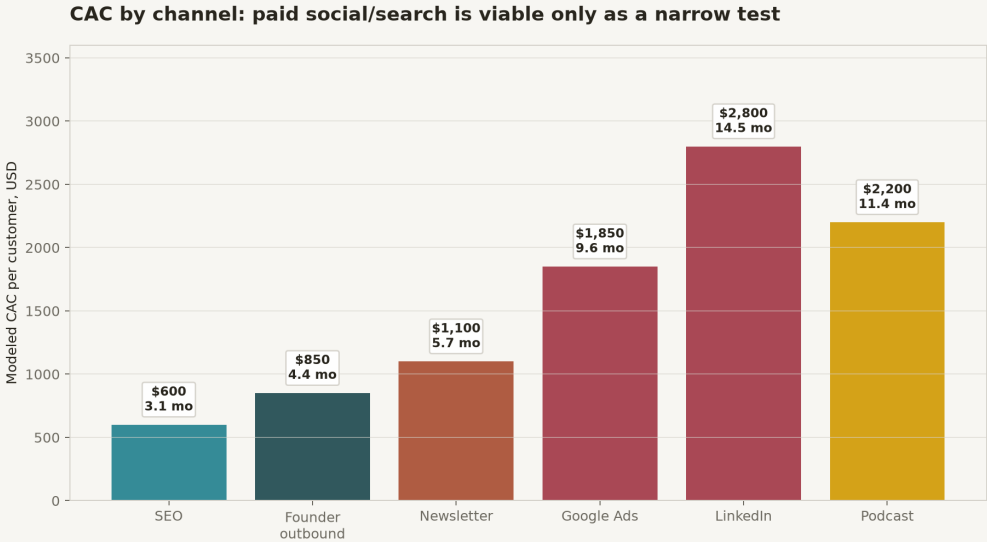
Modeled monthly acquisition funnel at steady state (months 6-12)



Stage	Modeled conversion	Measurement proxy
Visitors → engaged	25%	Docs depth, email, GitHub star
Engaged → evaluation	20%	Generator run or sample clone
Evaluation → intent	15%	Pricing view, founder DM, community question
Intent → purchase	20-33%	Checkout or invoice
Purchase → activation	70%	First module in staging within 30 days

CAC, Payback, and Unit Economics

Compliance tier carries the business; standard tier is community and data.



Tier	Y1 rev/customer	CAC	Payback	2Y LTV:CAC
Standard	\$1,139	\$760-\$800	~8 mo	~1.7-1.8x
Compliance	\$4,523	\$844-\$885	~2.2-2.4 mo	~6.1-6.4x

Pricing Page and Offer GTM

Transparent price, compliance anchor, and proof assets reduce trust friction.

Tier	One-time	Updates	Conversion role
Starter	\$499	\$299/yr	Low-friction entry and activation data
Professional	\$999	\$499/yr	Standard self-serve anchor
Team	\$1,799	\$799/yr	Small team bundle
Compliance	\$2,999	\$1,499/yr	Hero tier, founder-assisted
Compliance + AI Kit	\$4,499	\$1,999/yr	Regulated AI bundle

Guarantee

30-day money-back guarantee should be prominent, not buried.

Trust proof

Show sample evidence pack, architecture page, and commercial license clarity.

TCO anchor

Compare 3-year Caisson cost to Vanta-style annual SaaS, but avoid replacement overclaim.

Lifecycle, Retention, and Expansion

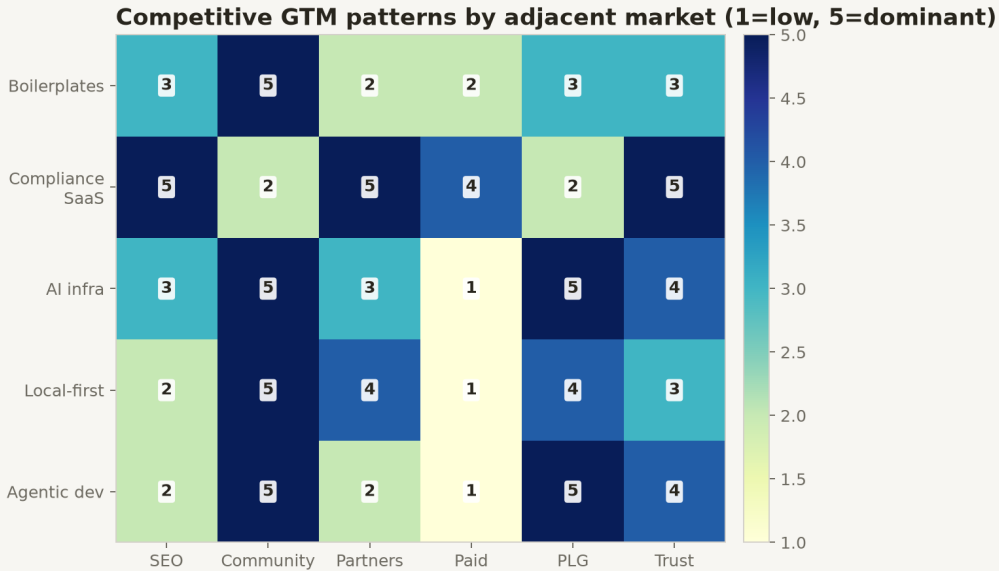
Update subscriptions are regulatory insurance, not generic maintenance.

Stage	Action	KPI
Day 0	License delivery + 30-minute success path	CLI run within 48h
Day 7	Generate first evidence pack	First audit event
Day 30	Activation check + NPS-style email	70% activation
Month 6	Case study/referral ask	15% public advocacy
Month 10-11	Changelog value summary + renewal preview	60% renewal

Renewal framing: Your perpetual license gives you the version you purchased forever. Your update subscription delivers architectural patterns that track EU AI Act, SOC2, and HIPAA changes so your compliance layer does not go stale.

Competitive GTM Teardown

Borrow patterns, avoid category traps.

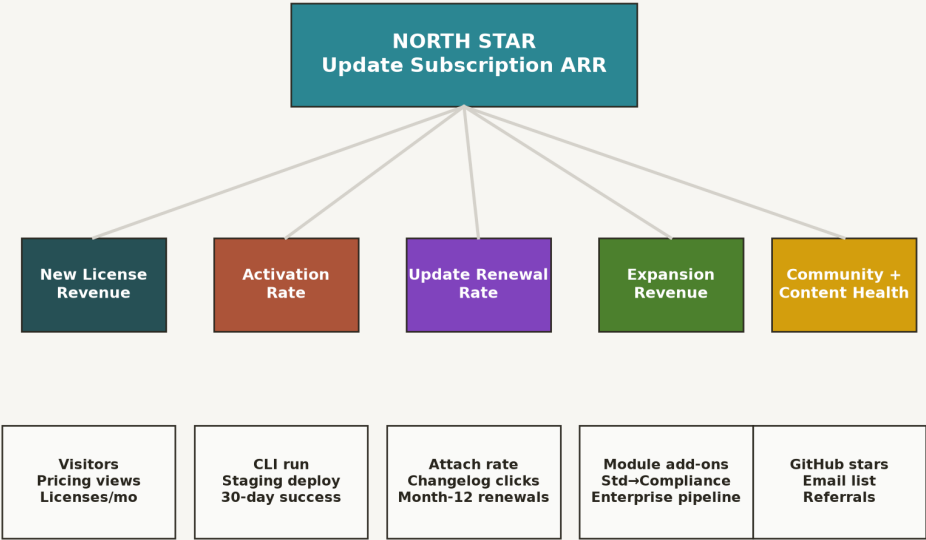


Group	Lesson	Trap
Boilerplates	Quantify time saved; self-serve purchase	Personal brand is not portable
Compliance SaaS	Partner refs and ROI calculators compound	Demo-gating too early
AI infra	GitHub-first trust; security posture sells	OSS without revenue fence
Local-first	Viral technical demo and integrations	Vocabulary too technical
Agentic dev	CLI-first; developer smuggling	No daily productivity loop

Measurement Operating System

The dashboard is useful only if tied to a decision cadence.

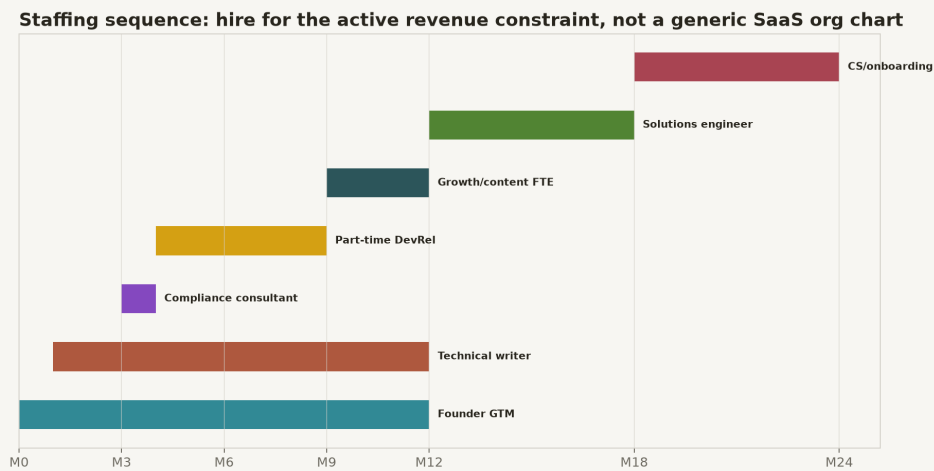
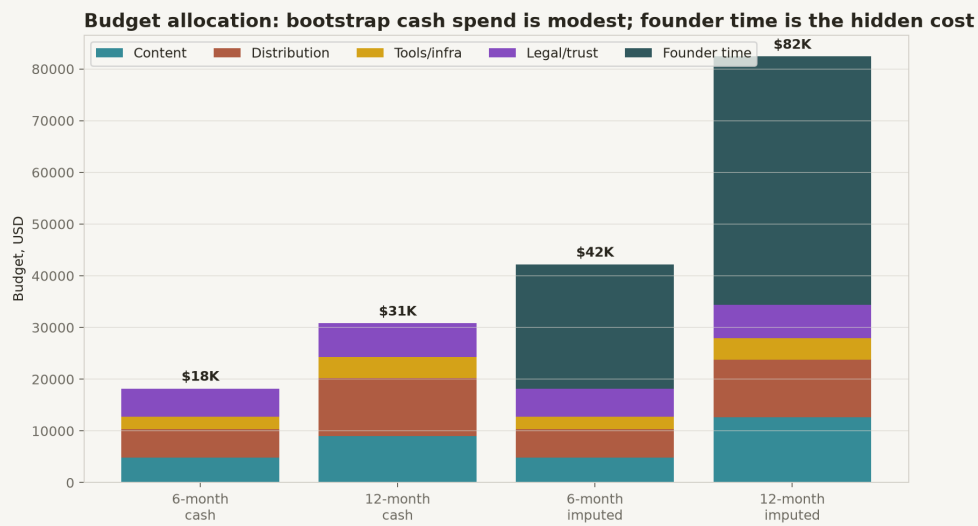
Metric tree: optimize recurring update ARR, not raw downloads



Cadence	Decision	Alarm
Weekly	Which 1-2 experiments run next?	<20 GitHub stars/week by M3
Monthly	Shift channel budget and content themes	<5 licenses/mo by M3
Quarterly	Reprice, reposition, or scale	CAC > \$1,500 or activation <60%

Budget and Resourcing

Spend on content, trust, and narrow distribution before broad paid acquisition.

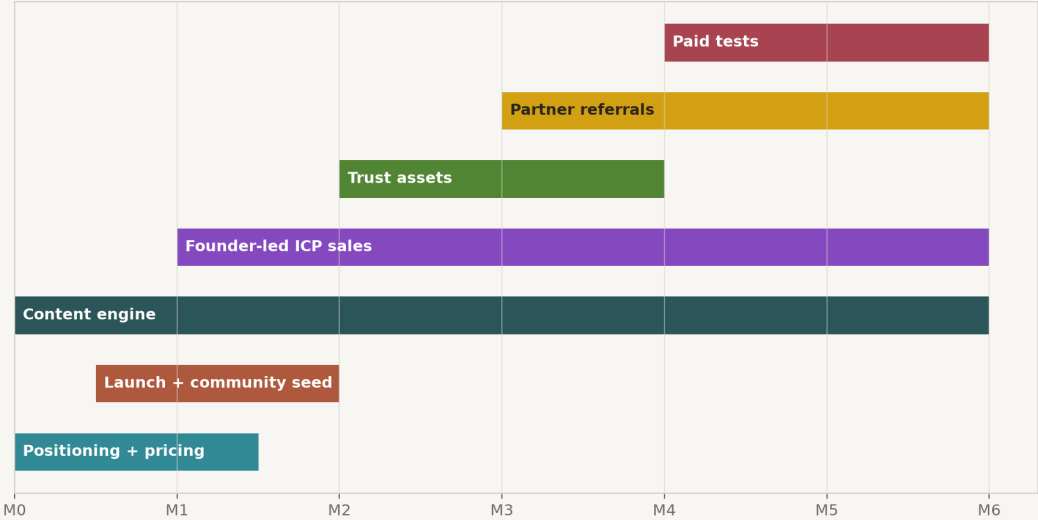


Operating recommendation: one founder plus a part-time technical writer can run the first 90 days. Outsource diagrams and compliance/legal review. Delay SDR, VP Marketing, and full-time paid acquisition until conversion and WTP are proven.

Scenarios, Roadmap, and Experiments

Validate compliance WTP before scaling paid acquisition.

6-month GTM roadmap: validate compliance WTP before scaling paid acquisition

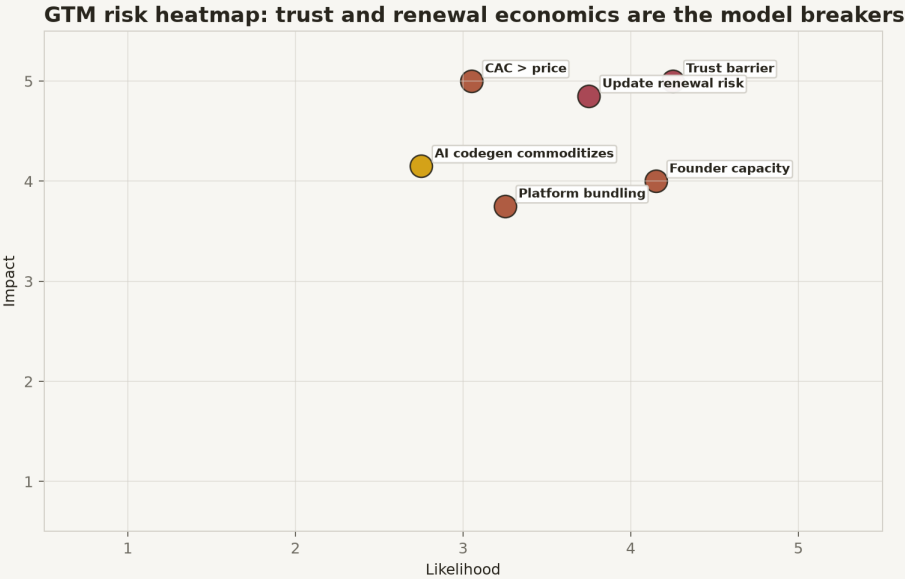


Scenario	Probability	Action
Base: compliance timing wins	60%	Execute content + first 10 logos
Upside: regulation forces buying	20%	Hire solutions help; prepare enterprise waitlist
Downside: AI codegen narrows moat	20%	Move up-market to attorney-reviewed patterns + services

Priority experiment	Metric
30-day guarantee prominence	Pricing conversion
Free EU AI Act starter module	Evaluation rate
Founder outreach to 50 CTOs	Compliance pipeline
Update sub at checkout vs. Day 30	Attach rate

GTM SWOT and Risk Heatmap

Trust and renewal economics are the model breakers.



SWOT	Points
Strengths	High-WTP compliance wedge; own-code differentiation; urgent regulatory narrative
Weaknesses	No incumbent trust; no hosted telemetry; one-time revenue lumpiness
Opportunities	EU AI Act timing; vCISO referrals; AI governance; agentic-dev codebase standards
Threats	AI codegen commoditizes; incumbents expand; platforms bundle; CAC exceeds price

Appendix: Methodology and Assumptions

Fact, estimate, and assumption labels used throughout.

Input	Value	Label	Validation
Compliance WTP	\$2,999-\$4,999 + updates	Assumption	20 ICP interviews, first 10 sales
Update renewal	55-65%	Assumption	First cohort; devtool founder interviews
Organic purchase CVR	1.5-3.0%	Estimate	First 100 organic conversions
Paid search CPC	\$6-\$10	Estimate	\$1K exact-match pilot
Demo-to-close	20-30%	Fact + estimate	CRM from first 25 calls

Key caveat: there is no public benchmark dataset for paid source-code libraries. This report triangulates from developer tools, compliance SaaS, security SaaS, LegalTech/RegTech, paid boilerplates, and OSS-to-enterprise infrastructure. Treat modeled economics as directional until Caisson has first-party funnel data.

Appendix: Selected Source List

Full URLs are included in the sibling Markdown report.

#	Selected source
1	First Page Sage funnel benchmarks, 2025
2	SEO Sherpa B2B SEO statistics, 2025
3	Dreamdata Google Search non-branded ads benchmark, 2025
4	ChartMogul SaaS conversion report, 2025
5	daily.dev Hacker News marketing benchmarks, 2025
6	daily.dev developer podcast advertising benchmarks, 2025
7	AdCommons newsletter ad costs, 2025
8	LinkedIn 2025 ad benchmarks via Scott Schnaars
9	WordStream Google Ads industry benchmarks, 2025 update
10	Optif.ai CPL by channel benchmarks, 2025
11	Zeliq B2B CPL benchmarks, 2025
12	Martal B2B cold email statistics, 2025
13	Belkins cold email response rates, 2025
14	PuppyDog demo-to-close benchmarks, 2025
15	Product Hunt launch statistics, 2025
16	Working Reference ShipFast GTM case
17	Makerkit SaaS starter kit cost analysis
18	StarterPick SaaS boilerplate market map, 2026

The Markdown companion file contains complete inline citations and full URLs for every benchmark, competitor teardown, and regulatory data point used in this PDF.